

Ways Companies Can Address the Situation



Set expectations around non-verbal misconduct, micro-aggressions, and coded language beyond what the law covers

Build gender-intelligent leaders by training them on unconscious bias, body language, and inclusive communication

Enable safe and early reporting by using anonymous channels, helplines, peer advocates, and third-party audits

Remove bias from evaluations with objective performance criteria to remove gendered expectations

Adopt transparent seating norms, balanced committees, healthy after-hours boundaries, and visible allyship

Motwani, Founder & CEO of Kinetic Green.

At its mildest, the male gaze makes women feel watched and at its worst, it becomes the precursor to explicit harassment.

LK, a young media professional in her first job, experienced this spectrum first-hand. What began as seemingly supportive guidance from her manager soon slipped into casual sexist remarks, unwarranted attention, personal probing, and repeated boundary-crossing. Over months, the behaviour escalated into inappropriate physical contact inside the office. She filed a complaint with the Internal Committee under the PoSH Act. Her manager resigned shortly thereafter but the experience compelled her to walk away from the career she had once been excited to build.

In addition to the trauma of being subjected to harassment, what affected her more was the shift in how she was made to feel second-guessed, watched and subtly isolated

and judged by her own colleagues. “It impacted my confidence and sense of belonging because I realised that speaking up often changes how others look at you rather than at the perpetrator,” says LK. She strongly believes that workplaces should ensure some check-in on the complainant in the aftermath.

Her experience illustrates a common pattern as women often anticipate not just retaliation from the perpetrator, but judgement from the ecosystem.

Out of the 24,000 professional women surveyed by global professional services firm Aon, in its 2024 Voice of Women Study, in India, 42% mentioned that they faced bias at work and 37% said they have experienced insensitive behaviour. Many reported that they faced workplace discrimination based on gender, age, and marital status; experienced microaggressions and dealt with career setbacks after maternity.

6% of the women (more than 1,400) admitted to fac-